

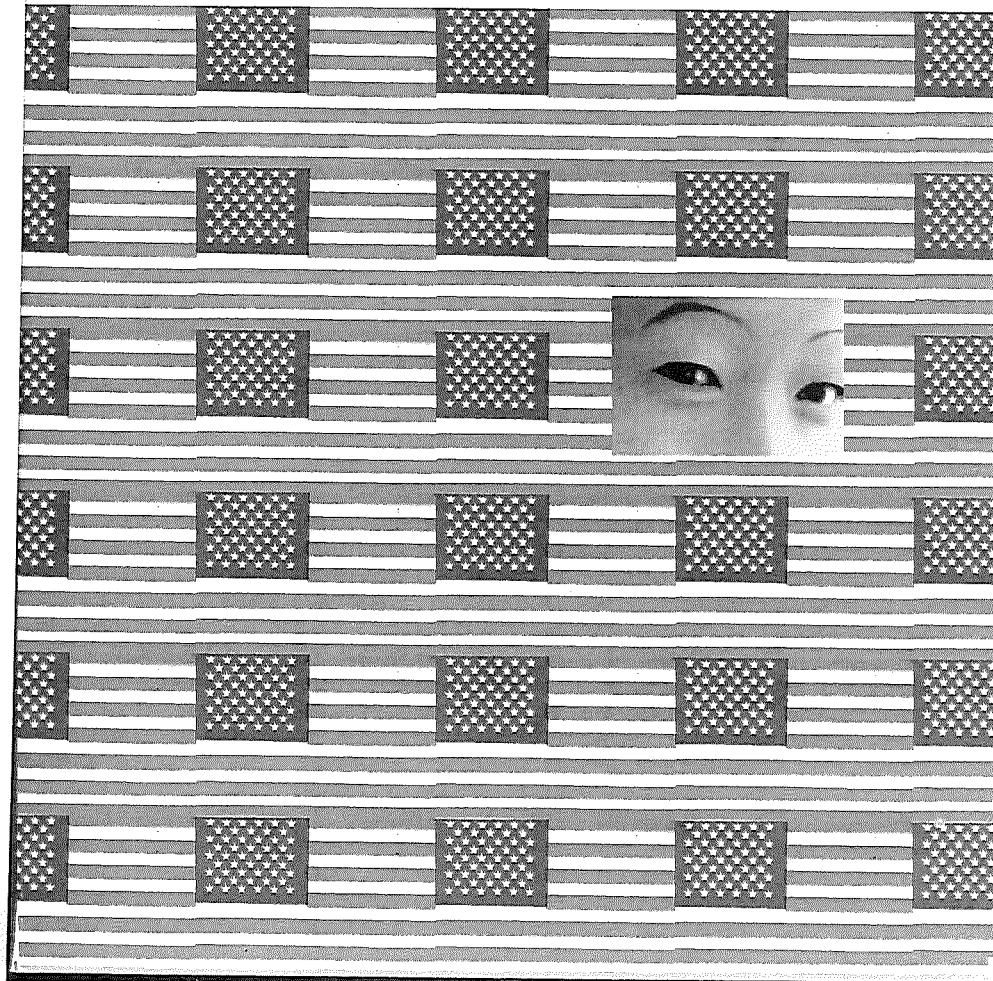
"Both hilariously funny and seriously important."—Amy Tan

Mona in the promised land

a novel

GISH JEN

author of TYPICAL AMERICAN



Why do you think Gish Jen chose to link Chinese Americans and American Jews in her novel?

Based on these chapters, what do you think these groups might have in common in their experience as American immigrant/minority groups?

Through her use of humor, what critique or commentary is Gish Jen making on themes like multiculturalism, assimilation, and the idea of America as a promised land?

Immigration presented as entering the promised land - but is America truly promised for them or for Jews regardless of race or religion considering how they are treated upon immigration?

CHAPTER I

Mona Gets Flipped

There they are, nice Chinese family—father, mother, two born-here girls. Where should they live next? The parents slide the question back and forth like a cup of ginseng neither one wants to drink. Until finally it comes to them: what they really want is a milk shake (chocolate), and to go with it a house in Scarshell. What else? The broker hints patiently, in a big round voice; she could have modeled her elocution on the cannonball. "The neighborhood!" she says, appreciating herself in the visor mirror. Her enunciation is something for someone doing her lips while she talks. Now she smooths her French twist. In smell she is cultivated, this realtor, a real Chanel No. 5; however, she is married to a conspicuously hairy husband, as the minor Changs know via spying skills and nosiness. She powders her nose. "Moneyed! Many delis!" In other words, rich and Jewish, she! for one! would rather live elsewhere!

This is such a nice thing to say, even the Changs know to be offended, they think, on behalf of all three Jewish people they know, even if one of them they're not sure about. Still, someone has sent the parents a list of the top ten schools nationwide, and so many-deli or not, they settle into a Dutch colonial on the Bronx River Parkway. For they're the New Jews, after all, a model minority and Great American Success. They know they belong in the promised land.

Or do they? In fact, it's only 1968; the blushing dawn of ethnic awareness has yet to pink up their inky suburban night. They have an idea about the blacks because of poor Martin Luther King. More distantly perceived is that the Jews have become The Jews, on account of the Six Day War; much less that they, the Changs, are The New Jews. They are just smitten with the educational opportunity before

Chinese as new Jews, educational opportunity

them—that golden student-teacher ratio—and also with the dumb majesty of the landscaping. Three giant azaleas they have now, not to say a rhododendron the size of their old bathroom, and in addition a topographical feature of forsythia. Two foothills of the forsythia they are moved to address immediately with hedge clippers (feeling quite hardy and pioneering, Westward ho! and all that), only to discover that to render your forsythia into little can shapes is in this town considered gauche. And so they desist. Leaving an effect, as their nice new neighbor, Mr. 20-20, helpfully points out. Older sister Callie dubs it *Two Small Cans with Wild Mountain Range*.

Still they figure there's much to admire about their house, what with its large brick chimney and considerable wood door, and not to forget its stucco-clad walls. Never mind that when younger sister Mona asks, she discovers stucco to be designer cement. They've never lived in a place *dad* in anything before. Their house is still of the upstanding-citizen type. *Remember the Mayflower!* it seems to whisper, in dulcet tones. They could almost be living on Tory Lane, that's how fetching their road is, how winding. So what if drivers miss their turns, plow up their flower beds, then want to use their telephone? *Of course*, Helen tells them, like it's no big deal, they can replant. They're the type to adjust. The lady drivers weep, Helen gets out the Kleenex for them.

The Changs are a bit down the hill from the private-plane set, in other words. Only in their dreams do their jacket zippers jam, what with all the lift tickets they have stapled to them, Killington on top of Sugarbush on top of Stowe; and they don't even know where the Virgin Islands are—although certain of them do know that virgins are like priests and nuns, which there were more of in the town they just moved from, than here. This is Mona's first understanding of class. In the old neighborhood, everybody knew everything about virgins and nonvirgins, not to say the technicalities of staying in between. Or almost everybody. In their old town, Mona was the laugh-along type. Here, she's an expert.

"You mean the man . . . ?" Pigtailed Barbara Gugelstein spits a mouthful of Tab back into her pop-top can. At this age she has chin-to-chest disease, but even so you can see how riveting are her dewy green eyes. These are not set in regular sockets like your everyday cup and ball, but rather in most exquisite deep hollows, big and thought-provoking

is this
a comparison of
appearance

as TV dish antennae. Naturally, she does not see this. Naturally, she is obsessed with hair frizz, and what's more is convinced that her nose resembles a half-open sleep sofa. To everyone else she looks like Cleopatra. Ostrich fans, she brings to mind. Languid nights on the Nile.

"That is *so* gross," she says.

Pretty soon Mona's getting popular for a new girl. The only hold-out is Danielle Meyers, who, what with her blue mascara and contact lenses, not to say other attributes, has gone steady with two boys. "How do *you* know?" she starts to ask. Proceeding to edify the eighth grade at large with how she French-kissed one boyfriend and just regular-kissed the other. ("Because, you know, he had braces.") They hear about his rubber bands, how once one popped right into her mouth. Mona begins to realize she needs to find somebody to kiss too. But how? She can't do mascara, her eyelashes stick together. Plus—as Danielle the Great Educator points out—*Mona's Chinese*.

Stereo types? Luckily, she just about then happens to tell Barbara Gugelstein she knows karate. She doesn't know why she tells Barbara this. Her sister Callie's the liar in the family, ask anybody; it's a result of looking exactly like their mother, only with granny glasses instead of regular. Callie's got the kind of beauty that makes you consider where you stand in life, whereas Mona doesn't see why they should have to hold their heads up. But for some reason, Mona tells Barbara she can make her hands like steel by thinking hard. "I'm not supposed to tell anyone," she says.

The way Barbara backs off blinking, Mona could be the burning bush.

"I can't do bricks," Mona says, just to set things straight. "But I can do your arm if you want." She sets her hand in chop position.

"Uh, it's okay," Barbara says. "I know you can—I saw it on TV last night."

That's when Mona recalls that she too saw it on TV last night, in fact at Barbara's house. She rushes on to tell Barbara she knows how to get pregnant with tea.

"With tea?"

"That's how they do it in China."

Barbara agrees that China is an ancient and great civilization that ought to be known for more than spaghetti and gunpowder. Mona tells her she knows Chinese. "Byeh fa-foon," she says. "Shee-veh. Ji-nu." This

Being
exhausted?

is Shanghai dialect, meaning, "Stop acting crazy. Rice gruel. Soy sauce." Barbara's impressed. At lunch the next day, Danielle Meyers and Amy Weinstein and Barbara's crush, Andy Kaplan, are all impressed too. Scarshill is a liberal place, not like their old town, where the Whitman Road Gang used to throw crab-apple mash at Callie and Mona, and tell them it would make their eyes stick shut. Here they're like permanent exchange students. In another ten years, there'll be so many Orientals they'll turn into Asians; a Japanese grocery will buy out that one deli too many.

But for now, the late sixties, what with civil rights on TV, they're not so much accepted as embraced. Especially by the Jewish part of town—which it turns out is not all of town at all, that's just an idea people have, Callie says, and lots of Jews could take them or leave them same as the Christians, who are nice too; Mona shouldn't generalize. So let her not generalize, except to say that pretty soon she's been to so many bar and bas mitzvahs, she can almost say herself whether the kid chants like an angel or like a train conductor. At seder, Mona knows to forget the bricks, get a good pile of that mortar. Also she knows what is schmaltz. Mona knows that she is, no offense, a goy. This is not why people like her, though. People like her because she does not need to use deodorant, as she demonstrates in the locker room, before and after gym. Not to say she can explain to them, for example, what is tofu (*der-voo*, they say at home). Her friends' mothers invite her to taste-test their Chinese cooking.

"Very authentic." She tries to be reassuring. After all, they're nice people, she likes them. "De-lish." She has seconds. On the question of what her family eats, though, Mona has to admit, "Well, no, it's different than that." She has thirds. "What my mom makes is home style, it's not in the cookbooks."

Not in the cookbooks! Everyone's jealous. Meanwhile, the big deal at home is when they have turkey pot pie. Her sister Callie's the one who introduced them—Mrs. Wilder's, they come in this green and brown box—and when the Changs have them, the girls get suddenly interested in helping out in the kitchen. Meaning, they stand in front of the oven, watching the cuckoo clock. Twenty-five minutes. Callie and Mona have a deal, though, to keep this activity secret from school, as everybody else thinks frozen food is gross. The girls consider it a big im-

provement over authentic Chinese home cooking. Oxtail soup—now, that's gross. Stir-fried beef with tomatoes. One day Mona says, "You know, Ma, I have never seen a stir-fried tomato in any Chinese restaurant we have ever been in, ever."

"In China, we consider tomatoes as delicacy." (With the sun behind her head, Helen looks to be a cross between a saint and an eclipse.)

"Ma," Mona says. "Tomatoes are Italian."

"No respect for elders." Helen wags her finger. Having been a reluctant beauty in her youth, Helen could now graduate to the dignified kind if her greater desire were not to try and shame Mona into believing her. She turns, abandoning her halo; sunlight washes with corny radiance her brow, her eyes, her mouth, all beautiful, as she scoots her glasses down and makes a gorilla face. "I'm telling you, tomatoes invented in China."

"Ma."

"It's true. Like noodles. Invented in China."

"That's not what they said in school."

"In China," Helen says, resorting to facts, "we eat tomatoes like fruit. Just like we eat apples here. Of course, first we drop them in hot water to take the skin off. Because, you know, Chinese people don't like to eat anything with the skin on."

And at this show of authority, Mona reluctantly makes a gorilla face too. For if she ever had to say what means Chinese, it would have to include a predilection for peeling grapes in your mouth without moving your jaw—also for emitting the peels without opening your lips. On the other hand, her mother once admitted that China was such a long time ago, a lot of things she can hardly remember. She said sometimes she has trouble remembering her characters, that sometimes she'll be writing along, and all of a sudden she won't be sure how the strokes go.

"So what do you do then?"

"Oh, I just make a little sloppy."

"You mean you fudge?"

Helen laughed then, but another time, when she was showing Mona how to write her name, and Mona said, just kidding, "Are you sure you're not fudging now," she was hurt.

Asians not embraced by Jewish part of town

She is descent to Jewish but Jews don't orientalize her

Sisters view their Chinese culture as less desirable compared to her culture. They find themselves immersed in it.

Asian - taking the Jewish culture

"I mean, of course you're not," Mona said. "I mean, *oy*."

Meanwhile, what Mona knows is that in the eighth grade, people do not want to hear about how Chinese people eat tomatoes without the skin on. For a gross fact, it isn't gross enough. On the other hand, the fact that somewhere in China somebody eats or has eaten or once ate living monkey brains—now, that's conversation.

"They have these special tables," Mona says, "kind of like a giant collar. With, you know, a hole in the middle, for the monkey's neck. They put the monkey in the collar, and then they cut off the top of its head."

"Whaddathey use for cutting?"

Mona thinks. "Scalpels."

"Scalpels?" Andy Kaplan is going to turn out the sort of spatial brilliant that can rotate irregular objects in his head, but for now he's just a pale sprout of a guy with spittle on his braces.

"Kaplan, don't be dense." Barbara Gugelstein straightens as if to lock into firing position her twin early maturities. "The Chinese invented scalpels." *kind of reminding me of Philip Serrano's sm. FDK*

Once a friend said to Mona, that everybody is valued for something. This friend explained how some people resented being valued for their looks, others resented being valued for their money. Wasn't it still better to be beautiful and rich than ugly and poor, though? *You should be just glad, she said, that you have something people value.* She said it was like having a special talent, like being good at ice-skating, or opera-singing. She said, *You could probably make a career out of it.*

Here's the irony: Mona is.

But to return: Mona is ad-libbing her way through eighth grade, as described. Then comes one bloomy spring day. Scarshell is everywhere azaleas and other understory plants offering year-round interest; even Mona is looking spriggy, what with the bluebell she has tucked behind her ear in the manner of a Honolulu tour bus hostess. This is not so easy on account of her glasses being in the way, and also on account of her having her father's ears—i.e., the fold-out kind that if life were fair would also fold in. These go, somehow, with her blue-ribbon cowlick, and best-of-class freckles; it's no wonder (not to boast) that

she has developed some aplomb to go with all these looks. How much aplomb, however, remains to be seen on said bloomy spring day, as she saunters in late to homeroom, only to experience a personal seasonal shock—a new kid in class.

Chinese.

So what should she do—pretend to have to go to the girls' room like Barbara Gugelstein the day Andy Kaplan took his ID bracelet back? She sits down. She is so cool she reminds herself of Paul Newman. First thing she realizes, though, is that no one looking at her is thinking of Paul Newman. The notes fly:

"I think he's cute."

"Who?" Mona writes back.

"I don't think he talks English too good. Writes it, either."

"Who?"

"They might have to put him behind a grade, so don't worry."

"He has a crush on you already, you could tell as soon as you walked in—he turned kind of orangish."

Mona hopes she's not turning orangish as she deals with her mail, she could use a secretary. The second round starts:

"What do you mean, who? Don't be weird. Didn't you see him???" Straight back over your right shoulder!!!!

She has to look, what else can she do? She thinks of certain tips she learned in Girl Scouts about poise. She crosses her ankles. She holds a pen in her hand. She sits up as though she has a crown on her head. She swivels her head slowly, repeating to herself, *I could be Miss America.*

"Miss Mona Chang." *Attractiveness & beauty is means of self-promotion?*

Her bluebell falls to the floor. Barbara rescues it for her, but still the blackboard ahead seems to swim with yesterday's homework equations.

"Notes, please."

Mrs. Mandeville's policy is to read all notes aloud.

Mona tries to consider what Miss America would do. She envisions herself, back straight, knees together, crying. Some inspiration. Cool Hand Luke, on the other hand, would quick, eat the evidence. And why not? She should yawn as she stands up, and boom, the notes are gone. All that's left is to explain that it's an old Chinese reflex. *Because people don't know about her culture she can make stuff up*

She shuffles up to the front of the room.

"One minute, please," says Mrs. Mandeville.
Doom looms.

Mrs. Mandeville loudly uncrinkles a piece of paper.

And Miss Mona Chang, who got almost straight A's her whole life except for in Math and Conduct, is about to start bawling in front of everyone.

She is delivered out of hot Egypt by the bell. Mrs. Mandeville still has her hand clamped on Mona's shoulder, though, and the next thing Mona knows, she's holding the new boy's schedule. He's standing next to her like a big blank piece of paper.

"This is Sherman," says Mrs. Mandeville.

"Hello," Mona says.

"Non how a," Mona says.

She's glad Barbara Gugelstein isn't there to see her Chinese in action.

"Ji-nu," she says. "Shee-veh."

Later Mona finds out that Sherman's mother asked if there were any other Orientals in his grade. She had him put in Mona's class on purpose. For now, though, he looks at her as though she's much stranger than anything else he's seen so far. Is this because he understands she's saying soy sauce rice gruel to him, or because he doesn't?

"Shah-man," he says finally.

Mona looks at his schedule card. Sherman Matsumoto. What kind of name is that for a nice Chinese boy?

(Later on, people ask her how she can tell Chinese from Japanese. She shrugs. It's the kind of thing you just kind of know, she says. Oy!)

Sherman's got the sort of looks Mona thinks of as pretty boy. Mon-signor-black hair (not monk-brown like hers), kind of bouncy—not the kind that lies down slick and flat, his is almost bushy. Crayola eyebrows, one with a round bald spot in the middle of it, like a golf hole. She doesn't know how anybody can think of him as orangish. His skin looks white to her, with pink triangles hanging down the front of his cheeks like flags. Kind of delicate-looking, but the only really uncool thing about him is that his spiral notebook has a picture of a kitty

cat on it. A big white fluffy one, with blue ribbons above each perky ear. Mona's opportunities to view this are legion, as all the poor kid understands about life in junior high school is that he should follow her everywhere. This is slightly mortifying. On the other hand, he's obviously even more miserable than she is, so she tries not to say anything. Give him a chance to adjust. They communicate by sign language, and by drawing pictures, which he's much more proficient at than she is, although not as fast. He puts in every last detail, even if it takes forever. She calls on her patience.

A week of this. Finally she explains, "You should get a new notebook."

He turns the sort of pink you associate with bubble gum and hyacinths.

"Notebook." She points to his. She shows him hers, which is psychedelic, with big purple and yellow stick-on flowers. She tries to explain he should have one like this, only without the flowers. He nods enigmatically, and the next day brings her a notebook just like his, except that her cat sports pink bows instead of blue.

"Pureety," he says. And, after a moment, "You."

He speaks English! Has he spoken it all this time? Pretty, she thinks. You. What does that mean? If that's what he said at all. She's assuming he means pretty, but maybe he means pity. Pity. You.

"Jeez," Mona says finally.

"You ahh wer-u-come," he says.

She decorates the back of the notebook with stick-on flowers, and holds it so that these show when she walks through the halls. In class, she mostly keeps her book open. After all, the kid's so new, Mona thinks she really ought to have a heart. And for a livelong day, nobody notices.

Then Barbara Gugelstein sidles up. "Matching notebooks, huh?"

Mona's speechless.

"First comes love. Then comes marriage, and then come Chappies in a baby carriage."

"Barbara!"

"Get it?" she says. "Chinese Japs."

"Bar-bra," Mona says to get even.

"Just make sure he doesn't give you any tea," she says.

Are Sherman and Mona in love? Three days later, Mona hazards

that they are. Her thinking proceeds this way: She thinks he's cute, and she thinks he thinks she's cute. On the other hand, they don't kiss and they don't exactly have fantastic conversations. Their talks are improving, though. They started out, "This is a book." "Book-u." "This is a chair." "Chai-a." Advancing to: "What is this?" "Dis is a book-u." Now, for fun, he tests her. "What is dis?" Already he speaks more slowly than he used to, and with less staccato. He throws in fewer extra syllables; he gets his accents in the right place. For actually, his English teacher at home taught him all this before, he just needed to get his mouth to listen. As for Mona, she dutifully answers, "This is a book" when he asks, as if she's the one who has to learn how to talk. He claps. "Good!"

Meanwhile, people ask her all about him, Mona could be his press agent.

"No, he doesn't eat raw fish."

"No, his father wasn't a kamikaze pilot."

"No, he can't do karate."

"Are you sure?" somebody asks.

It turns out he doesn't know karate, but judo he does. She is hurt she's not the one to find this out; the guys know from gym class. They line up to be flipped, he flips them all onto the floor, and after that he quits eating lunch at the girls' table with her. She's pretty much glad. Meaning, when he was there, Mona never knew what to say. Now that he's gone, though, she's still stuck at the *This is a chair* level of conversation. Nobody's interested in China anymore; it's just more and more questions about her and Sherman. "Got me," she's saying all the time. Are they going out? They do stuff, it's true. For example, Mona takes him to her family's restaurant, where they spray whipped cream in their mouths and eat fudge sauce straight from the vat. Also she takes him to the department stores. She explains to him who shops in Alexander's, who shops in Saks. She tells him her family's the type that shops in Alexander's. He says he's sorry. In Saks, he gets lost; either that, or else she's the lost one. (It's true Mona finds him calmly waiting at the front door, hands behind his back, like a guard.) She takes him to the candy store. She takes him to the bagel store. Sherman is

crazy about bagels. She explains to him Lender's is gross, he should get his bagels from the bagel store. He says thank you.

"Are you going steady?" people want to know.

How can they go steady, when he doesn't have an ID bracelet? On the other hand, he brings her more presents than Mona thinks any girl's ever gotten before. Oranges. Flowers. A little bag of bagels. But what do they mean? Do they mean *thank you, I enjoyed the trip*, do they mean *I like you*, do they mean *I decided I liked the Lender's better even if they are gross, you can have these*? Mona knows at least a couple of items were supposed to go to their teachers; Sherman told her that once and turned red. She figures it still might mean something that he didn't throw them out.

More and more now, they joke. For example, he often mixes up thinking with sinking—which they both think is so funny that all either one of them has to do is pretend to be drowning, and the other one cracks up. And he tells her things. For example, that there are electric lights everywhere in Tokyo now.

"You mean you didn't have them before?"

"Everywhere now!" He's amazed too. "Since Orympics-u!"

"Olympics?"

Nineteen sixty-four, he reminds her, humming the Olympic theme song. "You know?"

"Sure," Mona says, and hums with him happily, they could be a picture on a Unicef Halloween can. The only problem is that Mona doesn't really get what the Olympics have to do with the modernization of Japan, any more than she gets this other story he tells her, about that hole in his left eyebrow. This is from some time his father accidentally hit him with a lit cigarette—when Sherman was a baby. His father was drunk, having been out carousing, and his mother was very mad, but didn't say anything, just cleaned the whole house. Then his father was so ashamed he bowed to ask her forgiveness.

"Your mother cleaned the house?"

Sherman nods solemnly.

"And your father bowed?" Mona finds this more astounding than anything she ever thought to make up. "That is so weird."

"Weird," he agrees. "Fader bow to moder!"

They shake and shake and shake their heads.

Immigration & naturalization being referred to as conversion → forming
for becoming Jewish. All sorts of appropriations of identity are being conflated, treated as casual and trivial!

As for the things he asks her, they're not topics Mona ever talked about before. Does she like it here? "Of course I like it here, I was born here," Mona says. Is Mona Jewish? "Jewish!" She laughs. "Oy!" Is she American? "Sure I'm American," Mona says. "Everybody who's born here is American, and also some people who convert from what they were before. You could become American." But he says no, he could never. "Sure you could," Mona says. "You only have to learn some rules and speeches."

"But I Japanese."

"You could become American anyway," Mona says. "Like I could become Jewish, if I wanted to. I'd just have to switch, that's all."

He looks at her in alarm.

She thinks maybe he doesn't get what means switch.

She introduces him to turkey pot pies. "Gross-u?" he asks. She says they are, but that she likes them anyway. "Don't tell anybody." He promises. They bake them, eat them, agreeing turkey is just like chicken, only spelt differently. While they're eating, he's drawing her pictures with a pencil stub.

"Dis American," he says, and on a napkin he draws something that looks like John Wayne. "Dis Jewish." He draws something that looks like the Wicked Witch of the West, only male. *stereotypes*

"I don't think so," Mona says.

He's undeterred. Partly this is because there is next to no lead in the pencil stub; difficulty seems to bring out in him resolution. "Dis Japanese," he says, and draws a fair rendition of himself. "Dis Chinese," he says, and draws what looks to be another fair rendition of himself.

"How can you tell them apart?"

"Dis way," he says, and puts the napkin of the Chinese so that it is looking at the napkins of the American and the Jew. The Japanese is looking at the wall until Mona finds him a replacement pencil, a red one. Then he draws a color picture of a Japanese flag, so that the Japanese is looking at his flag. "Chinese lost in depart-o-ment-o store," he says. "Japanese know how to go."

"What do you mean?" says Mona.

"Atomic bomb dropped on only one people," Sherman says. "The Japanese do not forget." On the back of an old mimeograph sheet, he draws another Japanese flag, a bigger one, which he puts on the ice-

box door with daisy magnets. "In school, in ceremony, we dis way," he explains, and bows to the picture.

When Helen comes in, her face is so red that with the white wall behind her, she looks a bit like the Japanese flag herself. Yet Mona gets the feeling she'd better not say so. First her mother doesn't move. Then she snatches the flag off the icebox, so fast the daisy magnets go flying. Two of them land on the stove. She crumples up the paper. She hisses at Sherman, "This is the U.S. of A., do you hear me!"

Sherman hears her. *Mona's mother is Jewish - but Sherman hung up drawing of Japan -*

"You call your mother, tell her come pick you up."

He understands perfectly. Mona, on the other hand, is stymied. And how can two people who don't really speak English understand each other better than she can understand them? "But, Ma," Mona says.

"Don't Ma me." Helen hands Sherman the telephone. (This she accompanies with Kleenex, out of habit.) *Jews + Chinese both targeted during war*

Later on, she explains that World War II was in China too. "Hitler," Mona says. "Nazis. Volkswagens." She knows the Japanese were on the wrong side, because they bombed Pearl Harbor. Helen explains about before that.

"What Napkin Massacre?" says Mona.

"Nan-king."

"Are you sure? In school, they said the War was about putting the Jews in ovens."

"Also about ovens."

"About both?"

"Both."

"That's not what they said in school."

"Just forget about school."

Forget about school? "I thought we moved here for the schools."

"We moved here," says Helen, "for your education."

Sometimes Mona has no idea what her mother is talking about.

"I like Sherman," Mona says, after a while.

"Nice boy." Helen gives the icebox door a quiet slam.

Meaning what? Mona would ask, except that her dad's just come home from the restaurant, which means it's time to start talking about whether they should build a brick wall across the front of the lawn. Recently a car made it almost into their living room, which was so

*but Sherman hung up drawing of Japan - cbe flag
says it's because it's America but really it's b/c of ethnic conflict*

scary that the driver fainted and an ambulance had to come. "We should discuss this problem," Ralph said after that. "Find solution." In appearance, Ralph could be an archetype of himself—his ears still stick out, his hair still sticks up. He is as padded as ever. Also his elbows still tend to rise and float in the air when he talks, as if he is standing in his own private water tank. But internally he is given to abrupt resolutions and real changes of outlook, for example about solving this problem. And so, for about a week, every night they'll be discussing how.

"Are you just friends, or more than just friends?" Barbara Gugelstein is giving Mona the big cross-ex.

"Maybe," Mona says.

"Come on. I told you *everything* about me and Andy."

Mona actually is trying to tell Barbara everything about Sherman, but everything turns out to be nothing. Meaning, she can't locate the conversation in what she has to say. Sherman and she go places, they talk, one time her mom threw him out of the house because of World War II.

"I think we're just friends," Mona says.

"You think"—Barbara pulls up her fishnet stockings—"or you're sure?"

Now that Mona does less of the talking at lunch, she notices more what other people talk about. Who likes who, whether to wear pants to rec night, this place in White Plains to get earrings. On none of these topics is Mona an expert. Of course, she's still friends with Barbara Gugelstein, but Mona notices that Danielle Meyers has spun away to other groups.

Barbara's analysis goes this way: To be popular, you have to have big boobs, a note from your mother that lets you use her Lord & Taylor charge card, and a boyfriend. On the other hand, what's so wrong with being unpopular? "We'll get them in the end," she says. It's what her dad tells her. "Like they'll turn out too dumb to do their own investing," she says. "And then they'll get killed in brokers' fees and have to move to towns where the schools stink."

"I guess," Mona says, shifting her weight a little.

But the next thing Mona knows, she has a true crush on Sherman Matsumoto. Mister Judo, the guys call him now, with real respect; and

the more they call him that, the more Mona doesn't care that he carries a notebook with a cat on it.

Mona sighs. "Sherman."

"I thought you were just friends." Barbara Gugelstein lifts an eyebrow, something she learned to do last week.

"We were." Mona employs her own new air of mystery. For this, she's noticed, is how Danielle Meyers talks. Everything's secret, she only lets out so much; it's obvious she didn't grow up with everybody telling her she had to share.

And here's the funny thing: The more Mona tells people that she and Sherman are more than just friends, the more it seems to be true. It's the old imagination giving reality a prod. When Mona starts to blush, he starts to blush. They get to a point where they can hardly talk at all.

"Well, there's first base with tongue, and first base without," Mona tells Barbara Gugelstein.

In fact, Sherman and Mona have brushed shoulders, which was equivalent to first base, Mona was sure, maybe even second. She felt as though she'd turned into one huge shoulder. That's all she was, one huge shoulder. They not only didn't talk, they didn't breathe. But how can Mona tell Barbara Gugelstein that? So instead she says, "Well, there's second base and second base."

Danielle Meyers is her friend again. She says, blinking bluely, "I know exactly what you mean," just to make Barbara Gugelstein feel bad.

"Like *what* do I mean?" Mona says.

Danielle Meyers blinks bluely some more.

"You know what I think?" Mona tells Barbara the next day. "I think Danielle's giving us a line."

Barbara picks thoughtfully at her split ends.

If Sherman Matsumoto is never going to give Mona an ID to wear, he should at least get up the nerve to hold her hand. Mona doesn't think he sees this. She thinks of the story he told her about his parents, and in a synaptical firestorm realizes they don't see the same things at all.

So one day, when they happen to brush shoulders again, Mona doesn't move away. He doesn't move away either. There they are. Like a pair of bleachers, pushed together but not quite matched up.

To be popular, you have to have big boobs, a note from your mother that lets you use her Lord & Taylor charge card, and a boyfriend. On the other hand, what's so wrong with being unpopular? "We'll get them in the end," she says. It's what her dad tells her. "Like they'll turn out too dumb to do their own investing," she says. "And then they'll get killed in brokers' fees and have to move to towns where the schools stink."

After a while, Mona has to breathe, she can't help it. She breathes in such a way that their elbows start to touch too. This is in a crowd, waiting for a bus. They are both wearing short sleeves. She cranes her neck to look at the sign that says where the bus is going. Now their wrists are adjoining. Then it happens: He links his pinky around hers.

Is that holding hands? Later, in bed, Mona wonders all night. One finger, and not even the biggest one.

Sherman is leaving in a month. Already! Mona supposes he will leave and they'll never even kiss. She guesses that's all right. Just when she's resigned herself to it, though, they hold hands all five fingers. Once, when they are at the bagel shop; then once more, in her parents' kitchen. Then one day, when they are at the playground, he kisses the back of her hand. He does it again not long after that, in White Plains. She begins to use mouthwash.

Instead of moving on, though, he kisses the back of her hand again. And again. She tries raising her hand, hoping he'll make the jump from her hand to her cheek. It's like trying to wheedle an inchworm out the window. You know, *This way, this way.*

All over the world, people have their own cultures. That's what they learned in social studies.

If they never kiss, she's not going to take it personally.

It is the end of the school year. There've been parties. Kids've turned in their textbooks. *Hooray!* Outside, the asphalt steams if you spit on it. Sherman isn't leaving for another couple of days, though, and he comes to visit every morning, staying until Callie comes home from her big-deal job as a grocery checkout clerk. Mona and Sherman drink Kool-Aid in the backyard, holding hands until they are sweaty and make smacking noises coming apart. He tells her how busy his parents are, getting ready for the move; his mother in particular is very tired. Mostly he is mournful.

The very last day, he holds Mona's hand and does not let go even when their palms fill up with water like a blister. They talk more than usual. How complicated is his address, whether the Japanese have aerograms too. Then suddenly he asks, looking straight into his Kool-Aid, will she marry him?

I'm only thirteen.

But when old? Sixteen?

If you come back to get me.

I come. Or you come to Japan, be Japanese.

How can I be Japanese?

Like you become American. Switch.

He kisses her on the cheek, again and again and again.

His mother calls to say she's coming to get him. Mona cries. She tells him how she's saved every present he's ever given her—the ruler, the pencils, the bags from the bagels, all the flower petals. She even has the peels from the oranges.

All?

I put them in a jar.

She'd show him, except that they're not allowed to go upstairs to her room. Anyway, something about the orange peels seems to choke him up too. Mister Judo, but she's gotten him in a soft spot. They are going together to the bathroom to get some toilet paper to wipe their eyes, when poor tired Mrs. Matsumoto skids up onto the lawn.

"Very sorry!"

They race outside.

"Very sorry!"

Mrs. Matsumoto is so short that about all they can see of her is a green cotton sun hat, with a big brim. It's tied on. The brim is trembling.

Mona hopes her mom's not going to start yelling about World War II.

"It's all right, no trouble," Helen says, suddenly on the steps, behind Mona and Sherman. She's holding the screen door open; when Mona turns, she can see her mother waving. Helen is wearing a dress you would never guess she's mended twice, and she is practically standing on her toes, as if trying to hail a taxi. "No trouble, no trouble!"

"No trouble, no trouble!" Mona twirls a few times with relief. Sherman is blushing; the air smells of summer, which is to say of Mr. 20-20's roses next door.

Mrs. Matsumoto keeps apologizing; Helen keeps insisting she shouldn't feel bad, it was only some grass and a small tree. Crossing the lawn, she insists Mrs. Matsumoto get out of the car, even though it means mashing some lilies of the valley. She insists Mrs. Matsumoto

process of
Assimilating
integrating
as someone
A casual
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Switch
concerning
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childish

come in for a cup of tea. Then she will not talk about anything unless Mrs. Matsumoto sits down, and unless she lets Helen prepare for her a small snack. The coming in and the tea and the sitting down are settled pretty quickly, but there is more negotiation over the small snack, which Mrs. Matsumoto will not eat unless she can call Mr. Matsumoto. She makes the mistake of linking Mr. Matsumoto with a reparation of some sort. This Helen will not hear of. "Please!" "No no no no." Back and forth it goes. "No no no no." "No no no no." "No no no no." What kind of conversation is that? Mona looks at Sherman, who shrugs. Finally Mr. Matsumoto calls on his own, wondering where his wife is. He comes over in a taxi. A strong-jawed businessman, friendly but brisk, he is not at all a type you could imagine bowing to a lady with a taste for tie-on sun hats. Helen invites him in, as if it's an idea she just that moment thought of. And would he maybe have some tea and a small snack?

Sherman and Mona sneak back outside for another final good-bye, next to the house, behind the forsythia bushes. They hold hands. He kisses her on the cheek again, and then—just when Mona thinks he's finally going to kiss her on the lips—he kisses her on the neck.

Is this first base?

He does it more. Up and down, up and down. First it tickles, and then it doesn't. He has his eyes closed. Mona closes her eyes too. He's hugging her. Up and down. Then down.

He's at her collarbone.

Still at her collarbone. Now his hand is on her ribs. So much for first base. More ribs. The idea of second base would probably make her nervous if he weren't on his way back to Japan, and if Mona really thought they were actually going to get there. As it is, though, Mona isn't in much danger of wrecking her life on the shoals of passion. His unmoving hand feels more like a growth than a boyfriend. He has his whole face pressed to her neck skin so she can't tell his mouth from his nose. She thinks he may be licking her.

From indoors, a burst of far-off laughter. Her eyelids flutter, she can't help it. She starts to try and wiggle such that his hand will maybe budge upward. Does she mean for her top blouse button to come accidentally undone?

He clenches his jaw; and when he opens his eyes, they're fixed on

that button like it's a gnat that's been bothering him for more than long enough. He mutters in Japanese. If later in life he were to describe this as a pivotal moment in his youth, Mona would not be surprised. Holding the material as far from her body as possible, he buttons the button. Somehow they've ended up too close to the bushes.

What to tell Barbara Gugelstein? She says, "Tell me what were his last words. He must have said something last."

"I don't want to talk about it."

"Maybe he said good-bye? Sayonara?" She means well.

"I don't want to talk about it."

"Aw, come on. I told you everything about . . ."

Mona says, "Because it's private. Excuse me."

Barbara squints at Mona with her dewy green eyes as though Mona is a distant horizon she's trying to make out. She straightens her back maturely. Then she nods and very lightly places her fingertips on Mona's forearm.

The forsythia seemed to be stabbing them in the eyes. Sherman said, more or less, *You will need to study how to switch.*

And Mona said, *I think you should switch. The way you do everything is weird.*

And he said, turning pink, *You just want to tell everything to your friends. You just want to have boyfriend to become popular.*

Then he flipped her. Two swift moves, and she went sprawling through the late afternoon, a flailing confusion of soft human parts such as had no idea where the ground was.

It is fall, and Mona is in high school, and still he hasn't written. So finally she writes him on her new electric typewriter.

I still have all your gifts. I don't talk so much as I used to. Although I am not exactly a mouse either. I don't care about being popular anymore, I swear. Are you happy to be back in Japan? Jackie Kennedy married a Greek, but neither one of them switched—that's what Barbara says. What do you think

Assimilation of becoming any thing perceived in an absurd manner
 ↓
 "How can become American so God can switch to anything"
 ↑
 by observing amplified by how serious the take posibility of switching

about that? I know I ruined everything. I was just trying to be entertaining. I miss you with all my heart, and hope I didn't ruin everything.

He writes back in fountain pen: You will never be Japanese.

She throws all the orange peels out that day. Some of them, it turns out, were moldy anyway. She burns the letter with the help of Barbara Gugelstein. She tells her mother she wants to move to Chinatown.

"Chinatown!" Helen says.

Mona doesn't know why she asked.

"What's the matter? Still boy-crazy?"

"No."

"Forget about school."

Later she tells Mona that if she doesn't like school, she doesn't have to go every day. Some days Mona can stay home, like Callie.

"Stay home?" says Mona. In their old town, Callie and Mona used to stay home all the time, but that was because the schools there were *waste of time*.

"No good for a girl be too smart anyway," says Helen.

For a long time, Mona thinks about Sherman. But after a while, she doesn't think about him so much as she just keeps seeing herself flipped onto the ground. Lying there shocked, as the Matsumotos get ready to leave. Her head has hit a rock. Her brains ache as though they've been relocated in her skull. Otherwise, she's okay. She sees the forsythia, all those whippy branches, and can't believe how many leaves there are on a bush, every one green and paniculate and durably itself. And past them, real sky. She tries to remember what makes the sky blue, even though this one's gone the kind of gray you associate with words that end with *nk*. *Dank*. *Sunk*. *Stink*. She smells their neighbor's roses, but also she smells grass. Probably she has grass stains all over her back. She hears Helen calling through the back door, *Mon-a! Everyone leaving now and Not coming to say good-bye?* She hears Mr. and Mrs. Matsumoto bowing as they leave—or at least she hears the embarrassment in her mother's voice as they bow. She hears their car start. She hears Mrs. Matsumoto directing Mr. Matsumoto how to back off the lawn so as not to rip any more of it up. She feels the back of her head for blood. Just a little. She hears their *chug-chug* grow fainter and fainter, until it has

faded into the *whuzz-whuzz* of all the other cars. She hears her mother singing, *Mon-a! Mon-a!* until her father comes home. Doors open and shut. She sees herself standing up, brushing her shirt off so she'll have less explaining to do if someone comes out to look for her. Grass stains, just like she thought. She sees herself walking around the house, going over to have a look at their churned-up yard. It looks pretty sad—two big brown tracks right through the irises and the lilies of the valley, and that was a new dogwood they'd just planted. Lying there like that. She hears herself thinking about her father, and how he had always considered gardening a waste of time to begin with. *That's for rich guys*, he used to say; sometimes he just wanted to cut everything down with the lawn mower. It was only when he saw her mother out there digging the hole herself that he agreed to help with the dogwood. And now he was going to have to go planting the thing all over again. Adjusting. She thinks how they probably ought to put up that brick wall.

And sure enough, when she goes inside, no one's thinking about her, or that little bit of blood at the back of her head, or the grass stains. That's what they're talking about—that wall. Again. Helen doesn't think it'll do any good, but all these accidents are giving Ralph stomach gas. Should they or shouldn't they? How high? How thick? What will the neighbors say? They have to check about the zoning, Helen claims, but Ralph, eating a danish, seems suddenly to have never heard of such a thing. *Soning? Ah, zoning! Begins with "z."* Mona plops herself down on a hard chair. And all she can think is, they are the complete only family that has to worry about this. If she could, she'd switch everything to be different. But since she can't, she might as well sit here at the table for a while, discussing what she knows how to discuss. She listens and nods to the rest.

Her Life More Generally

When is a pickle dish more than just a pickle dish? Two years later, Mona ponders this in tenth-grade English class; also pickles in general. She used to love pickles, but now hesitates to bring them to school (even if they are satisfyingly crunchy and low-calorie to boot), for fear of setting off a sublimation lunch—i.e., the kind of lunch where everyone discusses which people are sublimating and, in particular, whether she is. Also if all of life, in reality, is sublimation. If it is, Mona would rather not know about it.

By now, Mona would love to have forgotten about Sherman—to have proven disloyal, impulsive, fickle, a regular *femme fatale*. But though she is in the sweet bloom of her youth, she hasn't exactly had to worry about catching mono like Danielle Meyers. There was that fling with DeWitt Traub freshman year—all forty-eight hours of it before he went back to Farah Liason, the ham radio queen. And it did also transpire once, after a Dead concert, that Mona somehow found herself slow-dancing with one of the roadies—a musician in his own right, it turned out, who used just one name for his first name and last name both. Jupiter. Of course, even he seemed to feel that something was missing, for when he introduced himself, he never said just Jupiter, period, but generally added *like the planet* in such a way that that almost seemed to be his last name. And after the nice warm dance, Mona told him that she had noticed this; which she later thought must have impressed him. For though, like his namesake, he proved to have many moons in orbit, he sent her a postcard a week for a good two and three-quarters months, and almost half of them

were addressed to her, Mona Chang, and not to Pee-pee Vulva, whoever she was.

All the same, her chief hangout is still Barbara Gugelstein, and one of their chief activities is a game called Wonder What Sherman Is Doing Right Now. It seems that this is how they have always whiled away their afternoons—imagining what Sherman is wearing, imagining what Sherman is eating, imagining whether Sherman is thinking about Mona. Of course, in all their imaginings, he is pining so desperately that his mother keeps having his blood drawn, thinking that something is the matter. He has decided to return to the U.S. He is obsessed with student exchange programs. He plays a game with his friends called Wonder What Mona Is Doing Right Now—only, of course, in Japanese. Does he, in his wildest imaginings, imagine that right at that moment, his Mona is actually imagining him, imagining her? “It kind of like blows your mind,” says Barbara Gugelstein.

Other interests: fashion. Mona and Barbara both wear ponchos, peasant blouses, leotards, bikini underwear. Hip-hugger bell-bottoms. Water-buffalo sandals. Barbara favors elephant-hair earrings and love beads; Mona has a necklace with a tear-shaped peace symbol she got in Greenwich Village. (This, she maintains, looks nothing at all like a declawed chicken foot.) She wears her hair long and straight and parted in the middle, as do Barbara and Cybill Shepherd, among other fashion leaders. At night, Barbara has to roll hers all up on an orange juice can; Mona has her cowlick to contend with. Sometimes she Dippity-Dos it down, but mostly she leaves it to do its anti-gravity thing.

A subinterest: fashion design. Mona uses scissors to get the bottom edge of her hip-hugger bell-bottoms to fray. Also she washes them a hundred times with bleach. She debates whether under her knee patches there ought to be real holes. She would cut some, except that Barbara Gugelstein told her she did that once, and then her jeans really ripped—not only across the front completely, but around the back too. Mona wonders about this. Didn't the rip get stopped by the side seams? Still, she doesn't exactly want to risk pedal pushers, given all the time she spent arguing about her pants with her mom.

“Waste water, waste electricity, waste soap, I don't know what is the matter with you,” Helen kept saying. “You want to wear old

Looking like the other girls

clothes, you can borrow some from your parents. Everything we wear is washed soft already. Save you a lot of work."

"You know, Ma," Mona said, "I'd be happy to pay for the electricity if you want."

To which Helen answered, huffily, "You want to pay for something, you can go stay in hotel."

This, for the record, is not what Barbara Gugelstein's mom would have said. At Barbara's house, the kids get fined if they're incurring costs over and beyond the reasonable. For example, with a bird phase: Somebody gave Barbara a pair of Australian zebra finches, which she decided to try and breed. And this, it turned out, was just like they learned in sex ed. You got the boy bird in the vicinity of a girl bird who hadn't gotten the big talk-to, and before you could say, *Think of your future* there were some hundred birds at least. They took up a whole wall. And these birds were not going to any four-year college, that was obvious. They were just flying around their cages, and kicking their seed out the bars, and generally making such a big delinquent mess that the maid insisted on being paid extra to clean it up.

It was just lucky Barbara could finance this. She got forty-five dollars for helping paint their backyard fence alone (that was fifty cents a picket for two coats plus cleanup). Also she gets paid for things like bringing in the paper and setting the sports section by her dad's cereal. For Barbara is her own separate accounting unit, unlike Mona and Callie.

Mona and Callie, that's to say, are slave labor. Never mind their handy on-call restaurant service. They mow the lawn and don't get paid. They vacuum the living room and don't get paid. They wash the storm windows and don't get paid, Callie especially—Callie's always been the power scrub of the family. But even Mona the mother's favorite helps dry and is not paid, not that it really matters. For even if they did get paid, they couldn't exactly spend the money on hot pants just because it was their money and they'd earned it. After all, this is what it means to be a family member: There is nothing so small but that you've got to ask the parents' permission. Once, Callie and Mona tried to unionize and go on strike, but instead of becoming folk heroes, they turned into Disappointments. "Mom's tired," Helen said, and they could see that she was. Who wouldn't be, working all the time the way she did? Some days she went straight from the restaurant

to bed, instead of going grocery shopping and doing the cooking; these were the days she was likely to start brooding about her family in China, wondering whether everyone was dead by now or still being tortured. The Disappointments came home to find their mother in her bathrobe; and then they felt about ready to put on their bathrobes too. For her mood had turned into their mood, it was like a forest fire jumping a ditch.

And so the girls toil on. Helen is always talking about who really suffered, as in "Your aunt Theresa, she really suffered"; from which the girls deduce that women distinguish themselves in life by their misery. Ergo, they strive to be as miserable as possible, Callie especially. For Callie used to want to be a martyr anyway, back when they were in Catholic school; she had that head start. Now she makes people feel sullied by the world, and in need of confession, and this is great, since she's on the school newspaper. "Scoop," everyone calls her, nobody gets the story like she does, she was even asked to be editor in chief. Naturally enough, though, she declined.

For this is the difference between Mona and Callie: Mona would probably have said sure, which is exactly why nobody is asking. Who needs to draw her out? After years of everyone emphasizing the Importance of Class Participation, Mona can finally be counted on to volunteer. With the result that at least one of her teachers, Miss Feeble, has begun to ignore her hand up in the air. Now, Mona, you have to give someone else a chance to talk. This she is not supposed to have to say to nice Chinese girls. So what does it mean that she has to say it to Mona?

Miss Feeble has apparently been pondering this question, because one day she asks Mona if she is really Chinese. This is while Miss Feeble pushes desks around, arranging them in a horseshoe.

"Of course I'm Chinese," Mona says, helping out. "I'm Chinese American."

"And your parents?" continues Miss Feeble, pushing. "They're Chinese too?"

"Of course," Mona says. "They're *immigrants*." She knows as she says this, naturally, that her parents would never use that word on themselves. They think it means people who try to bring live chickens on buses and don't own real suitcases.

All the same, it works on Miss Feeble.

Mona + Sister went to Catholic school, right?

Expectation of being a model minority + well-behaved + obedient + deferential to dominant culture

staid to standard success type?

"Ah." She repeats the holy word. "Immigrants." It is as if Mona has cut a little window into the fence of a construction site. Sure enough, there it is, the big crane.

The restaurant: This is not the first restaurant Mona's family's owned. The first was a fried chicken palace, to talk about which is now verboten, on account of it all but brought about the untimely demise of Aunt Theresa. How this came to pass is the complicated subject of another whole book. Suffice it to say here that since Theresa was the one who lay on death's doorstep, staring down that old house cat, she is the only one who can crack jokes about it now. Calling the chicken palace the Forbidden Palace, for example. Wondering wherefore the imperial freeze on the subject. It's not as if we staffed it with eunuchs, she'll say.

In response to which, everyone is supposed to laugh politely and not ask what a eunuch is, especially since she's sure to explain. For apparently this is what being plucked from the jaws of eternity will do to you; a certain derangement has to be expected. Now she's up and moved to California, where she strolls around on the beach with Uncle Henry all day—rumor has it, in a two-piece bathing suit and sometimes less, and without having gotten married, either. Leaving this narrator here to report that the one good thing about the chicken palace fiasco was that it forced Ralph and Helen to sell their house. Because that's how it was that they had the cash to go in on the new franchise Uncle Henry's old wife was buying. *One countertop*, Ralph and Helen joked then. But even that was a help to poor Aunt Janis; and with time, they could call more and more of the Formica their own—poor Aunt Janis having moved on to shopping centers.

So that the next thing they knew, they were moving too, out of their old town and into this Dutch colonial with landscape problems, as you've heard. For this is what pancakes can do. It's true the magic's been patchy at times, for example, the day dear old Fernando socked Cedric the new cook in the nose on account of some missing minute steaks. Cedric lifted an eyebrow at an inopportune time; and then it didn't matter who had really been stealing and who had not, Fernando had to be fired for punching.

Which was why he put a curse on the restaurant—sort of like the curse on the house of Atreus, Callie said, except that theirs was a house of pancakes; and hopefully nobody was going to get murdered in the bathroom like poor Agamemnon, who worked so much harder than that Aegisthus ever did. Still everyone was upset for a good long time. There was something in Fernando's voice, hoarse and crazed and serious, that made them wish they still believed in Buddha, or God, or Guan Yin—someone. They would have liked to have burned some money, left some fruit, lit some candles.

Instead they took refuge in the register. *Wha—innng!* They never completely forgot Fernando, or the unnatural strength of the outraged. But in time, it made them appreciate all the more what came quietly together for them. For ever since Helen started helping, the fact has remained: On those light-as-air stacks, the Changs did rebuild their lives.

Nowadays: They don't really have much to complain about, the girls. Except, well, that the pancake house isn't the greatest place for the lovelorn, especially on Saturday nights, when people you know are always coming in with other people you know. Mona dishes them up some extra-big scoops of ice cream, then goes to find herself some side work—unlike Callie, who won't come out of the back at all. She says she doesn't see why they should be working in the family restaurant when everybody else is out going to concerts to begin with. She says it isn't normal, and that she's sick of being Chinese. And with that, she plops herself on their father's red recliner and puts her feet up, as if officially taking a break from it—for which Mona can't blame her. She knows what Callie means, after all, even though neither one of them would ever say so to anybody but themselves.

It's not just the restaurant. It's not just the fact that they have a real brick wall blocking off their lawn. It's everything. For example, if one of them gets their father a bowl of rice before he asks for it, everyone approves. *She knows her father's mind*, say the parents. But if they know *their own minds instead, watch out*. And no one in their family is allowed to prefer not to eat something. If someone makes a face at, say, the fish, she has to eat the whole thing while everyone else watches.

*Mona + her sister
do not like
being
Chinese*

*Being
immigrants
+ having
different
lifestyles*

*Don't like not
being able
to be themselves +
don't like being horrible to
family*

Plus their father pushed their mother out the window once, and their bathroom doors don't close all the way, and the parents never wash the car. In fact, Mona had never even noticed that other cars got washed until someone wrote in big letters on the side of the Rambler: WASH ME! Now the girls do the car every single week.

Callie would sooner die than have anybody catch her in the dining room. But Mona figures everyone already knows the part about their being abnormal; waiting table isn't going to make any difference. However, Valentine's Day is hard, it's true. It makes Mona weepy to do the doilies and cherubim for the window. Do they have Cupid in Japan? And what about heart-shaped boxes, and funny little rhymes involving thees and thines; and what about long-stem red roses? Something about the long stems seems particularly un-Japanese to her, even though she realizes that to imagine everything in Japan to be short, like the people, is a type of thinking likely to result in low SATs.

Autumn: By this time, Mona has turned sixteen and gotten her learner's permit. This enables her to crash the car into the garage door the very same day that Barbara Gugelstein marches into the pancake house and announces that she's Jewish.

"Oh, really," Mona says, sharp-minded and quick. "Now, this is news. And what were you before?"

Barbara does not answer. Instead she takes out something from her pocket and begins to blow. This is not a harmonica, which would be bad enough. This is something more like a pipe crossed with a fire alarm—operating, it seems, on the principle of naked harassment. Customers spring up. Manny the salad boy glides forth from the kitchen like the priest he almost was; ever so effortlessly, he emanates a composure that spells crisis. Cooks Cedric and Alfred crane their necks behind him.

Mona, a bit sprung herself, says, "Barbara! Whaddayadoing?"

"Ancient Jewish music custom." Barbara starts to let loose another blast.

"Bar-bra," Mona pleads. "Most honorable friend."

"Please to give up on old jokes."

"So sorry," Mona says. "I just would fain see so good a personage start forsooth to toot her own horn."

Barbara laughs, tossing her hair.

"Nu?"

"A ram's horn," Barbara says. "It's for making new beginnings." She honks one more time. "Which I am now doing and which you should do too."

"Okay," Mona says. "Uncle. From today on, you are going to be Jewish. So, fine. But what do you want—that I should be Jewish too?"

Barbara laughs and tosses her hair again; it's the sort of instant replay that makes you realize something important must be happening.

And sure enough, next thing you know, they have embarked on a new chapter of their lives.

The New Chapter

Religion? Confirmation? In this anti-establishment age? Mona got confirmed in the Catholic Church, but she did it the way you were supposed to, which is to say with a certain big roll of the eyeballs. How can the classmates be discussing whether G-d is good or just neutral, and whether Judaism is a religion or a culture? Yet they are. Also they talk about what it means to be Jewish, which so far as they've been able to tell mostly seems to be about remembering that you are. Naturally, if you asked a rabbi, there's a lot more to it. But asking Barbara Gugelstein, the message comes back, *Don't forget, don't forget*. Mona tries to imagine what it would be like to forget she's Chinese, which is easy and hard. It is easy because by her lonesome she in fact often does. Out in the world of other people, though, Mona has people like Miss Feeble to keep the subject shiny. So here's the question: Does the fact that Mona remembers all too well who she is make her more Jewish than, say, Barbara Gugelstein?

A most interesting inquiry, especially since before you can say matzoh ball, Mona too is turning Jewish. It happens this way: Barbara gets her driver's license. Her parents buy her a VW van, despite their opinion of the Germans. And pretty soon Mona's tagged along to so many temple car washes and food drives, not to say weekend conclavettes, that she's been named official mascot of the Temple Youth Group. There she is, helping build the sukkah for Sukkoth—knotting up the corners, arranging the roof boughs so as to avoid overt danger to human life and limb. She's even helped give tours to some of the Youth Group members' parents, who have never seen a sukkah before, and want to know what it means. They poke at the shaky walls from the outside. Mona explains edifyingly how the gaps in the roof

appear due to faulty construction, but in fact afford a view of the sky symbolic of the desire to live spitting distance from G-d.

"Come Yom Kippur, those kids are going to be swinging chickens around their heads," mutters one, but Mona reassures him.

"How orthodox can they be?" she says. "After all, here I am."

The man works his sinuses as if he is in an Excedrin ad. He slides thumb and forefinger down his nose; he raises his bleary gaze. "Don't you have a home?"

"I do."

"Then what are you doing here?"

Trusty Barbara Gugelstein, rising to Mona's defense, says, "This is her home, you turkey."

"That's right!" chime in some other kids. "You tell him!"

"What?" says the man. "You live here?"

"I guess you could call it my home away from home," Mona says.

"I get it. It's your vacation place. Some people go to Palm Beach, you come here."

Mona shrugs. "Why spend the airfare?"

The man laughs and leaves. But two days later, Mona's still chewing the cud of this conversation. A stranger in a strange land, that's her, she concludes after two more days of rumination. Finally she approaches Rabbi Horowitz, who turns out to be less easygoing than he seems. He looks like a Hasid turned rock star, what with his long black hair and his untrimmed beard, and he doesn't mind being called Rabbi H., or the Big R.H., or even Rabbit H. He is young enough to sit cross-legged; he listens to Crosby, Stills and Nash; he plays the harmonica. He doesn't insist that anyone learn Hebrew, much as he'd like to encourage it. But when it comes to a sixteen-year-old choosing her own faith, what he professes to hear is mainly the reaction of other people. That of her parents, for example. Is she sure she doesn't want to see a school counselor? Rabbi Horowitz connects up his thick flat brows, so that they look just like the road by which one thing leads to another. He worries about her parish priest, who happens to play shortstop in their Batters of Conscience League (their cheer: *Holy Homers!*), and also about the temple board of directors. With the board it seems he is not so popular already, being anti-Vietnam, and also pro things like letting the kids wear what they want at confirmation, including bare feet.

"To tell you the truth, I'm not so sure I'll even be here next year," he finishes, cracking his knuckles.

Isn't that all the less to keep him from helping her?

"Also," he says—and by the way he clears his throat, Mona can tell that he is coming up on his real point—"I have to wonder, excuse me, how serious is this wish."

"You mean, whether this isn't my just wanting to be like my friends?"

"Like your friends, and also, an important factor at your time of life, unlike your parents."

Behind the rabbi's shoulder hangs a full-size human skeleton, with a fedora hat and necktie—something of which his parents would undoubtedly approve. Mona does not point this out. Instead she says, "You mean, is this adolescent rebellion? Maybe. But also I like it here at the temple. I like it that you tell everyone to ask, ask, instead of just obey, obey. I like it that people are supposed to be their own rabbi, and do their business directly with G-d. I like it that they're supposed to take charge of their own religion, and that they even get to be general-rabbi-for-a-day when they get bar and bas mitzvah. In the Catholic church, you know, you're always keeping to your place and talking to God through helpers. I like it that you tell people to make a pain in the neck of themselves."

"Who told you to make a pain in the neck of yourself?"

"Brian Levi." This is the TYG adviser. "And I don't mean to sound conceited, but I figure I'm a natural at that."

"At making a pain in the neck of yourself?"

Mona smiles sweetly.

Rabbi Horowitz's eyebrows come far enough apart for Mona to see what nice laugh lines he has. He wheels back in his chair, rattling Mr. Bones. "Brian is speaking for some Jews," he says. "Other Jews think you should study your whole life before you should dare to make a challenge. Sure you can talk to G-d yourself, and how can you learn if you don't ask questions? But without study, what are you? An ignoramus."

"I am!" agrees Mona. "Although I practically celebrate the High Holy Days already, and know that hamantaschen are supposed to represent the hat of that What's-his-name, may he roast in hell, Haman." As is proper, Mona stamps her feet to drown out the name of the infidel.

Rabbi Horowitz laughs aloud. "There's more to Judaism than that," he says, and the studying begins. Mona finds out for starters that God revealed the Torah in seventy languages (including Chinese), so that everybody could understand it; it just so happened that only the Jews read it through. Also that in Roman times, the Jews did lots of proselytizing. If she'd lived then, she could've probably just signed right up to be a fellow sufferer. But sign 'n' pray went out with the toga. Now the idea seems to be to discourage prospectives three times in theory—in practice, as much as is practical. Rabbi Horowitz assigns so many books that Mona feels like she started on a mud bath, only to end up on a mud swim.

Still she slogs through. A lot she knows already. All about the holidays, for example, and what is a mitzvah—namely a good deed. Also what is rachmones, namely a type of mercy every human should extend to others but sometimes doesn't. That part is easy and fun. It's like watching a home movie, you get that little shiver of recognition. Aha! So that's why they light eight lights at Hanukkah, and not seven or nine. Then there are new parts Mona likes—all the big ancient stories of blood and gore and guile. Rabbi Horowitz makes her glad she never had to put up with those stiff the Egyptians—what do you expect from people who wore so much eye makeup—or wander around the desert for forty years. She feels concerned for those ten lost tribes of Israel. She wishes she'd been around for the liberation by the Persians and the era of the Great Prophets. She likes debating like a Pharisee faced with a stick-in-the-mud Sadducee. She likes looking at maps, especially now that she's finally getting her real driver's license. What a down-to-earth religion this is! It's not like Catholicism, with people electing to get crucified upside down, as if right side up wasn't bad enough. The whole purpose of Judaism seems to be to avoid these things when possible. And why should rabbis be celibate? It does seem more natural to let them dutifully procreate, that instead of manning their seminal gates, they might sprinkle the earth with useful ideas. Things they can do about the world, for example. How they can help, how they can fix, how they can contribute and illuminate; and how they can stay, forever and ever, Jews.

The last subject is one on which Mona could use a *Guide to the Perplexed*—it's okay to turn into a Jew, but not to turn out of one?—and

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even harder to take in is not only the Holocaust, but the whole endless history that spirals up to it like a staircase in a nightmare. It winds on and on, a torchlit, hellish thing, bristling with caesars and czars; there's a lot to contemplate about the nature of this sweet world and most noble humanity. Do her happy friends in Scarshill with their patios and lounge chairs really live at the mouth of a stone age tunnel? It was hard to make out at first, but now she can see it plain, their own express lane down the centuries.

It makes her want to dig in her heels and extend them a steadying hand, though in fact, they're more likely to steady her. For while Callie and Mona know what it's like to have rocks thrown at them, this kind of welcome is for their family a novelty. Their group hasn't always been the oppressed. They used to be the oppressors; and that makes them, as a minority, rank amateurs. The Changs don't have their friends' instincts, or reflexes. They don't have their ready alert. They don't have their friends' institutions, or their ways of reminding themselves who they are, that they might not be lulled by a day in the sun. Prescriptions and rituals, holidays and recipes, songs. The Jews have books, they have games, they have tchotchkes. They have catalogs. And soon, G-d willing, so will Mona.

In the meantime, she is not the only one starting anew. Callie is being allowed to go to college, even though Helen found out over the summer that Callie's roommate was named Naomi, which she thought might be a black name. Not, of course, that Helen and Ralph had anything against blacks. In fact, they had a lot of blacks working for them at the restaurant. For example, Alfred the number-two cook. But seeing as how they happened to know someone who had a friend who had a daughter also going to Harvard, they couldn't help but wonder why this nice Chinese girl and Callie couldn't room together. This nice Chinese girl had a roommate too, Helen pointed out. Why couldn't this nice Chinese girl's roommate room with this Naomi? Helen said that she also knew somebody who knew somebody who worked in the financial aid office; maybe she could arrange something. And there was someone who knew someone who knew someone who worked at the Faculty Club. That's where all the professors have lunch, said Helen. Even the president himself eats there.

"Mom, those people can't do anything," argued weary Callie, sewing on name tags. "Especially since there's nothing the matter with a roommate turning out to be black. And anyway, the last thing I want to do is room with some nice Chinese wonk who's going to study all the time."

To which Helen managed to answer both "Not everyone Chinese studies all the time, that's *stereotype*" and "It would be good for you to study all the time with your roommate. Study together is nice."

Now it turns out that Naomi is indeed brownish black as the most serious-looking spines of her considerable personal library. Naomi works on her shelving system; the parents leave Callie to assist. How diligent this Naomi! And how well she speaks English!

The parents appear relaxed. On the way home, though, Mona notices that the car seems unexpectedly empty, a regular rattletrap, even though it is loaded full of Callie's boxes (which she personally collected from dumpsters all over the county). And when they get home, Mona discovers another unexpected thing: that she has her parents all to herself. This is not something she had counted on. In fact, Mona had rather expected they would think of nothing but Callie, their daughter at Harvard. Instead it is as if Mona is suddenly famous, the most interesting person in the room, every day, all day, even when she's asleep. If she goes out, it's only to be replaced by her palpable absence. *Where's Mona? How long has she been gone for? What time is she coming back home?*

Once, when Mona's ballet class was doing *Swan Lake*, her teacher gathered all the young cygnets around her. She described how Anna Pavlova beat her arms, and elongated her neck, just exactly like a real swan, though of course Pavlova never hissed, or bit anyone. And then this teacher described the effect all this beating and elongating had on the audience: *It stirred them*, she said, pulling up her leg warmers. (She knit these herself, with a pattern she copied out for her students for free.) It stirred them so much that the day Pavlova died, nobody could bear the thought of an understudy. Of course, this class would still have understudies, in case somebody got the hiccups, or the mumps, or something. But when Anna Pavlova died, the show went on without anyone. The light was moved around just as if she were there, and the audience pictured her in its mind's eye—pictured her beating her arms and elongating her neck.

And now, as with Anna, so with Mona. Truly: she could up and

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Assimilating
to some degree
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expire, and her parents would still be moving the beam around. Imagining where she would be if she were there, and in what fine fashion she would flap. This makes it hard to work on turning Jewish. If only Callie would come home! So Mona wishes, most ardently.

Until, all too soon, Callie does.

Thanksgiving already. At temple, Mona has begun to consider with Rabbit H. the holidays, and how very much she unfortunately likes the family Christmas tree. Not that they have always had the tasteful real Scotch pine they have now, with the fresh woodsy scent and the tendency to drip real pitch on the living room carpet. Before they moved, they used to unpack their tree out of a box, and sort out the silvery limbs by size, and poke them into little coded holes in the tree trunk. They had a revolving colored light to shine on it, so that it would turn blue, then red, then yellow, then green, and there was a Styrofoam tree skirt too, all sprinkled with glitter that used to fall off. New Year's Day meant having to vacuum that glitter up. But the Changs liked that tree and its rituals, or at least Mona did—even the vacuuming. If you asked her, she'd have to say that she's only just gotten used to the idea that they now have a new kind of tree, with a fabric skirt—the kind of skirt that matches the kind of people who say, as they do now, “fridge” for “icebox,” and “wastebasket” for “garbage.” That's to say that it's hard to contemplate moving on—already!—from a basic change of tree to no tree at all.

Yet that seems a distinct possibility, not just because of her conversations with Rabbi Horowitz, but also because of Callie. Is this what it means to be sisters, to come up with the exact same idea, only for opposite reasons?

When Callie first comes home, all's simple hilarity. Callie has changed her hair; she hadn't meant to go so short, but her roommate Naomi was doing the cutting, and though she started at Callie's waist, she ended up above her shoulders. This makes Callie, by the standards of the day, practically bald. But Callie doesn't care. She says at least all her split ends are gone. (Plus it makes her cheekbones stick out, and her lips look swollen up as if they maybe got bit by a bug.) She and Mona and Helen stay up past their bedtimes, way later than they ever have before, giggling on Callie's bed. Helen has her slippers on the wrong feet, and is sitting cross-legged with one of her pajama buttons

undone; Mona tells dirty jokes and even Helen laughs, covering her mouth with her hand. They discover that all three of them know what is a diaphragm, even though each of them thought the others couldn't possibly, and only Callie knows how to spell it. With a g, she says; they can look it up in a dictionary if they don't believe her. And so they do. A silent g! It's almost enough to make Mona want to go to Harvard too, to learn such things. Never mind that Callie insists she didn't learn this at Harvard and wishes Mona would stop saying that. Especially since she isn't even going to Harvard, she's going to Harvard-Radcliffe, and anyway she learned how to spell *diaphragm* from reading *Goodbye, Columbus*. A serious book, she maintains, although under questioning she admits that she originally only read it because the movie version was being filmed over at the high school. And because it had a diaphragm in it.

It is ascertained that for all concerned, a knowledge of reproductive technology is theoretical. The topic swerves to Ping-Pong diplomacy, and how mainland China can join the U.N. when it is not even a proper country but a bunch of leather-eating peasants. “You mean like belts?” Mona asks. “You mean like shoes?” Helen nods. Mona wants to know if they cook them first, and how. With soy sauce? With ginger? “That was only on the Long March,” says Callie. “Those Communists eat rats too,” says Helen, “and what do you call—you know, on the head? Lice.” The night goes on. Did So-and-so really hitchhike all the way to Chicago, just to find So-and-so had completely given up baking? Does So-and-so really bleach her underarms?

The next day, turkey. As a surprise, Ralph has arranged for the head waitress to come serve the meal. Magdalena has had a fight with her family and has nowhere to go, he says. He offered for her to just come and eat, but she insisted she'd rather help out. So what could he say? Of course, he knew from the beginning that she would offer something like this. He claims the real reason he made the offer was so that Helen wouldn't have to run around like crazy the way she usually does.

But Helen knows a gift horse when it kicks her. “Your father just like to act like big shot. He thinks this is China.”

A familiar complaint. In fact, one of the lilting refrains of their melodious lives. Sometimes it seems like no one even has to sing;

everyone can hear how annoying it is that Ralph should treat the help like far-flung family—buying them glasses and dentures and shoes, but also expecting them to run errands, or help fix the furnace at home. In general, he is getting better. He is learning to say, *That's your problem*. Also to expect people to say it to him. But from time to time he suffers relapses, and now what to do? Send Magdalena home?

"I always thought you like to sit there, doing nothing, instead of run around, do this, do that," Ralph says, cleaning out his ears. (Though they stick out, he still has to pull at them to get a good angle.) "Act like lady. Join some country club. I thought you sick and tired of work in the restaurant all day, then come home and work again."

"What did you say?" Helen is so stunned by this acknowledgment of her efforts that it seems she needs to clean her ears out too. "You hear that?" She addresses Mona and Callie. "Your father actually noticed that someone works at the restaurant and then comes home and works some more. All these years he acts like the food we eat comes from heaven, but actually he has his big eyes open all the time."

"Of course, I see everything," says Ralph, bugging his eyes first at Mona and then at Callie. They laugh. "And that's why this Thanksgiving, our nice waitress Magdalena coming here to help." He winks and grins, triumphant, only to have Helen set aside her hurt with breathtaking speed.

"This is the U.S. of A.!" she says. "Who has a waitress come to serve at Thanksgiving? Who?" She appeals again to the girls. They shrug obligingly.

But in the end, she doesn't want to fight in front of Magdalena, or to spoil Callie's first visit home, or even to show Ralph up. (It's bad enough the pancake house only started running in the black with her help.) Plus she feels sorry for Magdalena.

And so Magdalena swoops around. She sets Ralph's and Helen's plates down gently in front of them. However, Mona's and Callie's she sends skating down the wood-tone table, the way she would at the restaurant. What a champion she would be at horseshoes! The plates stop just in front of the girls; everyone claps.

She murmurs modestly, in her husky staccato, "I practice every day." She rolls some more *r*'s on request. Then she sits down with the family to eat. Troubles or no, she is sweetly flamboyant, thick-scented

as a gardenia farm. Her long hair coils like a black and white snake on her head; she applies makeup with the feathery restraint of a diva. Still, in small things she attends to nicety. For instance, she expresses polite amazement that they stuff the turkey with stir-fried rice stuffing; also that Ralph carves the turkey with a knife and chopsticks.

"Is that your Chinese tradition?" she asks.

Ralph nods gravely. "This is the Chinese tradition when we cannot find the big fork."

No sooner have they sent Magdalena home, though, than the subject of Christmas shopping comes up. This spurs Callie to announce that she doesn't think they should have a tree anymore.

"Naomi says it's a symbol of oppression."

Helen nods amiably. "Did Naomi go home see her family too?"

"Naomi says Christmas trees aren't indigenous to China." Callie says this with an insistence that is rare for her; she is not exactly the type to steer the conversation like a grocery cart. Even Helen has remarked how, though Mona and Callie have identical voices on the phone, you can easily tell who's who once the conversation gets going. If it twists and turns, it's Mona. Callie does not exactly hold forth.

Or at least she didn't use to. Now that she's at practically Harvard, though, she seems to have points to make, ideas to advance, albeit with more doggedness than bravura.

"Indigenous means what?" says Helen.

Callie thinks. "Natural."

"Native," Mona supplies. "I had that on the PSATs, and *natural* wasn't even one of the choices."

"Native." Helen mulls it over.

"Native means what?" asks Ralph, cutting the crust off his second piece of pie.

"Guess," Mona says.

"A kind of Indian people?"

While Helen translates for Ralph, Callie whispers to Mona, annoyed, "I was just trying to define it in a way they would get." Ralph nods; Callie goes on. "Naomi says we should hate them just as much as you hate Panasonic radios. She says you probably didn't have Christmas trees, growing up, why should you have one now? She says we should stick to our guns, like the Jews."

*expected to
be like Jews + avoid certain cultural
practices*

Mona pretends to be choking on her whipped cream.

"But we did have Christmas tree, growing up," says Helen evenly, one hand in her lap. "Every year. Not so a big tree as we have here, but still, we had it. Shanghai, you know, is a big city, we have everything. You know what we eat every morning in Shanghai? Bagels."

"Bagels!" Mona says.

Helen says the bakery used to string them together by the holes the way that people once used to string money. That was a long time ago, she says, when coins had little square holes in the middle.

"It was just because you went to a convent school that you had a tree." Callie is so busy talking that she hasn't eaten one bite of dessert. "The question is why you were going to a convent school to begin with."

"It was run by missionaries," says Helen. "French missionaries. Oh! We played a lot of tricks on them. I remember one nun especially, we used to call her Boat Feet, and when she came down the hall—"

"They were imperialists," says Callie, still not eating. "That's what Naomi says. They were bent on taking over China and saving the heathen. But you weren't heathen. You were civilized."

"Of course we were civilized," says Helen. "Chinese people invented paper. Chinese people invented ink, and gunpowder. We were wearing silk gowns with embroidery before the barbarians even thought maybe they should take a bath, get rid of their smell."

"But is that what the missionaries thought?"

"Oh, the missionaries just wanted to teach us some nice songs in French, and to tell us what nice food they eat in France. Especially they have nice pastries. The Chinese, you know, don't think so much about dessert." Helen looks at Callie, as if to reinforce her point.

"And to convert you, right?"

"Of course," says Helen. "But we don't mind."

"You didn't mind?" So nonplussed is Callie that she picks up her fork by accident. "But didn't you use to be Buddhist?"

"Oh, well, we are still Buddhist after we are baptized," explains Helen. "We are Buddhist, and Taoist, and Catholic. We do however we want." She maintains that her family liked having a Christmas tree, and that it was fun, and that it had nothing to do with oppression.

Callie finally eats. Still she insists later that she will have nothing to do

with the tree this year. Also she says that in the spring she's going to drop French so that she can take Chinese instead.

Everyone laughs.

Mona expects that when Rabbi Horowitz hears she is in charge of the family Christmas tree, he will tell her that her days as a prospective convert are up. Instead he gives her the kind of nod you associate with deeply significant moments in the movies—column A but column B moments, Mona calls these. In this case, disappointed but understanding.

"It's like an election. Some votes you win, some votes you lose. You're all right so long as you've got more on your side than the other," he says, straightening a pile of books. "Also you must realize that these days a lot of Jews have trees. It's not kosher, but that's the way it is. If they don't have a tree, they have a bush, and at the top they put the Star of David. And for you, please understand there's a lesson in this."

"What kind of lesson?" says Mona.

"The lesson of a lifetime." He gestures at his book-lined study. "What you're discovering is that it's not so easy to become Jewish. As, excuse me, I believe I tried to tell you. You can read and study, study and read, but still it will probably take you your whole life."

"My whole life?" Mona gulps.

And all over Christmas break, while everyone else is eating and opening and trying on and exchanging for credit or cash (including Callie the anti-imperialist), this is what Mona is pondering. Does she want to be converting for the rest of her life, Amen? New Year's Day, she drags around with such a heavy heart that when it comes time to take down the tree, Callie offers to help—also taking this opportunity to comment on how bushy the tree was this year. And why did Mona insist on getting a new star for the top when the old one worked fine?

For a resolution, Mona considers giving up converting. It seems against the spirit of New Year's—who resolves to strive less?—but so what. Rabbi Horowitz is right. Kosher is great, but nonkosher is the way things sometimes happen to be.

Just when she is ready to break the news to him, though, he naturally

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American means whatever you want

Is there absurdity demonstrated in Helen's opposition to
Mona being Jewish considering the rhetorical similarity?

Jews do so a similar in to
larger American culture

enough. decides he's impressed enough; it's time to order her to her optional mikvah. And so it is that on a melty January morning, Barbara and Mona drive over to the bath. This happens right after Mona's real license arrives in the mail, so that Mona is for her inaugural celebratory spin able to drive herself and Barbara through the fresh-fallen slush to the ceremony—which, it turns out, is not unlike getting baptized by John the Baptist, except with chlorine. It's not so easy to get her hair to submerge; Mona is called upon to employ her best sinking skills. But finally, success. Through a sheet, three witnesses listen solemnly to the dunk. She chants her Shema Israel. She burns her special four-stranded candle. Her three witnesses sign neatly her nice framable certificate. And in this way, she becomes Mona-also-known-as-Ruth, a more or less genuine Catholic Chinese Jew.

Maybe there are people who do not accept her, as Rabbi Horowitz has warned. Also it is tricky to be a solo Jew with no family. Still, it is a promotion to be no longer a mascot. The TYG throws a shindig in her honor; Mona attends happily a host of seminars, slide shows, art exhibits. For orphans she makes caterpillars out of knee socks; for the elderly she makes draft dodgers, also out of knee socks.

The only problem is that she has been unable to break the news to her family. And so it is that when Helen finds out, it is from Saint Callie at Practically Harvard, who you'd think would have better things to talk about. Like what she thinks about the coed bathrooms now that the novelty's worn off, and whether there really is a pool where everybody swims naked. Or what about a recap of how Harvard plays football against Yale every year? Callie told them that already, but Mona knows there were details she left out—for example, how everybody has to sit on concrete to watch, except people who are smart and bring pads. This might not be conversation for everybody. However, her parents, Mona knows, would be captivated.

Instead Callie has to go passing on some high school gossip she heard from somebody who knows somebody who knows somebody.

"Callie told us some surprise." So neatly does Helen fold up her Chinese newspaper, you would think she was planning to return it to the newsstand for credit. "She said you weren't going to tell us. She said you were going to keep it a secret. She said you did it behind our back."

"I guess I forgot to mention it," Mona says.

"Don't tell me that. That's . . . that's . . ." On the wall, the cuckoo clock ticks louder than normal. "That's *crap*."

"Ma! That's no way to talk." Mona wags her finger, expecting her mom to smile.

But Helen looks as though she's about to start crying. Her eyes redden; her face whitens. If she put a carrot on her nose, she would look just like the snowman that happens to adorn her at-home sweater. "A lot of *crap*!" She takes a drink of her tea. "Who do you think you are, you can lie to your mother like that?"

Mona looks down, penitent.

Helen goes on with a delicate bang of her cup. "You are daughter. Daughter. Do you remember what is a daughter?"

"I remember."

"Who are you?"

"I'm your daughter."

It's like being in church, right down to the moment of silence—which Mona takes to be a chance for Helen to turn misty-eyed again, that Mona might feel what a Disappointment she is. Helen swishes around some tea in her mouth, a good sign. Mona makes a gorilla face, and out of habit, her mother almost makes a face back. But in the midst of furrowing her brow, she suddenly starts talking.

"We agree, except what kind of daughter lies to her mother?"

"No kind."

"I have no daughter."

"What about Callie?" Mona means to be comforting.

Helen claps the lid on her teacup. "You know, you bring shame on our family, you act this way. What do you think people think of us?"

Mona contemplates the kitchen table.

"People talk, how do you think I feel? You have no consideration for others. You have no consideration for how other people feel."

Above Helen, the hour is struck. The clock door swings open, but what you see in place of the long-broken cuckoo bird is (courtesy of Callie) a glued-on Statue of Liberty pencil sharpener. *Cuckoo!* this cries. *Cuckoo! Cuckoo!*

Mona shrugs.

"Wiggle your shoulders is not a way to talk. How can you be Jewish? Chinese people don't do such things."

"They don't?" Mona asks this in her smallest, meekest voice—just wanting by this point to say the right thing, the thing that will make Helen look hurt again. Then Mona can feel ashamed, and they can make up, and Mona will be her mother's favorite once more. But what is that thing? Mona thinks and thinks. Still the right thing will not come to her—which must be why she abruptly gives up and says the opposite of what she should. As the Statue of Liberty pencil sharpener retreats, Mona says in her school voice, as if she's talking to Miss Feeble, "I guess I must not be Chinese, then."

"What do you mean, not Chinese?"

And from there on in, they are stuck in the land of words, until as they are no longer speaking to each other and are forced onward to the land of deeds.

There was a time when Helen made this trip quietly, if at all. How demure she was! It was Ralph who barreled through life, crackerjack active. But since then they've switched positions, one fading back right when the other came forward, the way the day bird replaced the night bird, back when there were birds in the cuckoo clock. For Helen was so mad when she realized Ralph couldn't take care of her—wasn't that what a husband was for?—that she had what amounted to a personality transformation. She'd gotten used to the idea of helping, of working hard, even of going out of the house to work. But she'd never adjusted to the idea of becoming a main pillar of the family, standing there all by herself like the kind of ruin people went to Greece to see. In a way, she was proud of what she'd learned to do. But in another way, this so wasn't what she'd counted on, growing up in China, that if you pointed out how energizing was her fury, she'd probably give you a nice maternal whack such as would excuse you from gym for a month. Mona knows this because Helen's done it to Callie from time to time—not meaning to, of course. And of course, it's not as if she hasn't been whacked herself. In fact, Ralph can be credited with pioneering the whole tradition.

But whereas he has given up that sort of thing in practice, Helen has given it up in principle. So that in a way, Mona is getting off easy when Helen confiscates her Hebrew dictionary, and her menorah, as well as the mezuzah Barbara made for her out of some parchment and an avocado-green toothbrush holder. She says something about having Ralph take her door down.

Ralph, though, first wants to get the facts straight. He sits Mona down at the kitchen table when he comes home; he turns on all the lights, as if to help him see better. His face is soft with worry, and he has mysteriously equipped himself with a pad of paper, a mechanical pencil, and a slide rule. Also the soles of his feet are planted on the floor, in position to lever him forward. *How do you get this idea? When is the first time you go with your friend? Who is the driver?* She tells him everything—what the traffic was like, what the weather report was, how they had trouble parking. He listens as if he is hoping to discover a clue to her—as if he hopes to find out that one morning Mona ate something fishy, only to come down with this idea in the afternoon.

Of course, he hasn't always been like this, so methodical. It is how he learned to be as a result of his impulsive youth. *Things are not always how they look*, he likes to say now, and *Watch out before you leap*. Has somebody tricked her into turning Jewish? He himself has been tricked, he says, with a slight averting of his face; and Mona knows, naturally, that here he is referring to the disaster that was the chicken palace. Still Mona says, "You? Really?" as if there was no one in the world she could imagine less trickable—which is true in a way. These days he turns every stone, he thinks of all the angles. *In back every wise man is fool*, he likes to say, although he is also quick to point out that not every fool becomes a wise man, and also that it is not easy to tell the fools from the wise men. *For the really wise men, they like to look as if they are fools*. He nods to himself, and with this chestnut, switches the lights back off.

Only to have another light turn on, illuminating the slight crevasse between him and Helen. Is there an icy split between every two people in the world? Anyway, this one is blue and wide and deep, and cold enough, Mona's sure, to freeze a child or two to death, though thankfully there are ways of skipping right over it. It's just a matter of watching where you put your feet, and keeping a certain spring to your step, and figuring a crack's a crack. Helen has to care extra about everything, for example, because he doesn't keep up his end. To wit: He does not even care who really suffered and who didn't. To him, everyone's suffered. To talk about it is just a matter of sitting one person on a little higher branch than another, and what are people doing up in a tree to begin with? He says this with his Ancient Wisdom voice, which to Helen is the voice of someone who isn't even trying

anymore. In her opinion, all he does is philosophize—he might as well be a hippie. She thinks that if it weren't for her, who knows, he would probably stop taking baths, which of course matters, seeing as it separates people from rhinoceroses and hippopotamuses and other low-standard animals who consider mud wallowing a proper way of life.

What surprise then that according to Ralph, this whole affair with Mona's converting is nothing to flip your lid over; whereas to Helen it takes absolute top place in an entire escalating series of incomprehensible and distinctly menacing developments, such as Mona's buying a down jacket, and her wanting not only her own car, which she can forget about, but her own telephone line. (Which she can forget about as well.) There is no use in talking to Helen about rachmones, or about her converting too, never mind the act of remembering, which Rabbi Horowitz calls the doorway to wisdom. There is no use in reminding her that Mona is her favorite child, and that she, Helen Chang, likes a lot of American things herself.

For if you asked her, she would say that she signed up for her own house and garage, but not for her children to become big-mouthed separate accounting units, and what is the matter with a regular coat with a nice interlining such as she has worn her whole life? "There's nothing warmer than down," Mona tries to tell her, but all Helen hears is what she wants to ask next—namely, why should Mona need her own telephone line? "So you won't eavesdrop," Mona says. To this Barbara Gugelstein's mother certainly would have said, "I don't eavesdrop," even if Barbara could hear her munching potato chips as she listened in. Once she even broke into the conversation to give some advice; she couldn't resist. Helen, on the other hand, said, "If I like to know what my daughter is up to, I don't see what's wrong about it." It all has to do with the Chinese way versus everyone else's way, as Mona sees it, but Helen doesn't even agree with her on that. "I think I'm very Westernized. I brought you children up without you even speak Chinese." Helen points out that some of her friends make their children all sit together around a big table at night, and study. They work out problems together, and none of them puts the stereo on loud; in fact, they don't even own records. Mark and Carole Louie's kids, for example, have no idea who is Jimi Hendrix. Which sounds like a path to a National Merit Scholarship, except that one of the boys set the curtains on fire, and another one got in trou-

ble for climbing the water tower and throwing rocks from the top. It wasn't a lot of rocks—after all, he had to carry them up in his pockets. But he got a JD card for it just the same. "The way they live is too difficult for the children," Helen said when she heard. "The parents should be like bamboo, bend in the wind. Not stand there stiff, like a telephone pole."

"That's right," Mona says now, during yet another discussion of her religious freedom. "You are the one who brought us up to speak English. You said you would bend like bamboo instead of acting like you were planted by Bell Telephone. You said we weren't pure Chinese anymore, the parents had to accept we would be something else."

"American, not Jewish." Helen assigns Mona a piece of pork to slice while she herself cleans the fish, and it calms them both down to see what a nice job Mona can still do—thin, and across the grain. (Lucky for them, Mona is the reformed kind of Jew that does not observe the many rules regarding fins and hoofs, mollusks and ruminants.)

"Jewish is American," Mona says. "American means being whatever you want, and I happened to pick being Jewish."

"Since when do children pick this, pick that? You tell me. Children are supposed to listen to their parents. Otherwise, the world becomes crazy. Who knows? Tomorrow you'll come home and tell me you want to be black."

"How can I turn black? That's a race, not a religion." (Mona says this even though she knows some kids studying to be Bobby Seale. They call each other brother, and eat soul food instead of subs, and wear their hair in the baddest Afros they can manage.)

"And after that you are going to come home and tell me you want to be a boy instead of a girl."

"Blood, Mom," points out Mona.

Helen glances up at the cuckoo clock as she crooks a knife-nicked finger; she runs it under the faucet while starting to stir-fry the pork with her other hand. After the pork, there is still the fish and also some spinach to do, and then it's time to get back to the pancake house. Behind her, the space heater flares up in ominous fashion. The kitchen used to be the warmest room in the house, but recently they had to turn the radiator off because of a leaking valve. "And after that you are going to come home and tell me you want to be a tree."

"Whoever heard of someone turning into a tree?" Mona tactfully

Both Helen + Rabbi generally mean a "correct" way of engaging w/ culture

Assimilating into American but not even on civil level
what Helen wants-

Jews still too foreign? Viewed as a separate group like Chinese are?

American means whatever you want - America allow for multiculturalism so she can engage w/ multiculturalism

even if it seems bizarre

refrains from bringing up this poet Ovid her English class is reading, never mind that he didn't write in English. Instead, she gets her mom a Band-Aid. She goes to sleep thinking that they have had a heart-to-heart communication such as leads to true intergenerational understanding and tolerance.

The next morning, however, Mona discovers her new down jacket outside on the milk box. This is after some searching that Mona finds it, and with some surprise. Did Helen really put it out there to freeze all night? Mad as Helen's been of late, Mona still can't imagine her doing such a thing; and later she finds out that it was in a way her father's idea. If Helen was so upset, he said, why didn't she just throw the jacket out? (That's Ralph for you, always a proponent of the concrete solution.) Except it wasn't so simple, in the end. Outside was dark and cold, and Helen didn't feel like going all the way to the garbage cans.

Now Mona has unmasked her treachery. "How can I wear this? It's freezing."

"Nothing warmer than down," Helen quotes her.

"How could you do this?"

Mona must look really forlorn, because Helen softens. "Oh, not that big a deal, you don't have to cry," she says, and taking the jacket from her daughter, she drapes it on top of the space heater to warm. "There." She says this in a leave-it-to-mommy voice she seems to have learned from TV, even though the Changs don't have a TV. (*The idiot box*, Ralph calls it.)

"Ma," Mona says, "I don't think that's such a good idea."

But Helen is the mother, and Mona is the daughter, which means that Helen knows what is a good idea and what isn't. And so it is that they take the jacket back off the heater really at the first whiff of trouble, before too large a hole has been burnt. Still down goes exploding through the kitchen. Who could believe a couple of jacket baffles could produce such a veritable snowstorm? But it just goes to show what a good value Mona got on her jacket, that so much went into it. There are goose feathers flying everywhere. Mona and Helen have to wave their hands in front of their faces to keep from breathing them; Helen very sensibly closes the door to the dining room while Mona opens the regular window, and the storm window too. Cold air rushes

in as she tries to shoo the feathers out. "A broom!" Helen cries, and so they try that. Sweeping at the air with long swings, short swings—they could be the sorcerer's apprentice, it's that effective.

Still they keep on, so that this is what they're doing when Mickey the milkman appears on the other side of the sill.

"Having a problem?" Mickey is a trim man with an ever-moist mustache they have ascribed to nasal drip; Mona stops shooing feathers in his face, for fear one might stick.

"Oh, no," Helen says, nonchalant. "Just helping my daughter with her homework."

"It's a science project," Mona says. "There's a contest at school."

"Well, good luck with it," says Mickey. "God knows, if I had any money I'd put it on you two." He walks away whistling; they hear the gate bang shut then bounce open, an old problem. They sneeze.